

Titularity & Disciplinary Identity

Abstract

This study challenges an unexamined assumption in the philosophy of science: the label “applied X” reliably indicates a substantive continuity with its parent discipline. It advances an epistemic grounding thesis, according to which disciplinary identity depends not on naming, methods, or institutional affiliation, but on the alignment of core epistemic goods and problem space. Building on recent work in the philosophy of interdisciplinarity, I reconceptualize unilateral problem-feeding as a mechanism of epistemic substitution and distinguish between integrative pluralism and degenerative pluralism that erodes disciplinary coherence. Through an analysis of applied linguistics, I argue that titular continuity can mask a deeper transformation in epistemic orientation, resulting in disciplinary misclassification. I further justify that disciplinary institutional drift can explain how such misalignments are stabilized and reproduced. More broadly, I call for a reassessment of interdisciplinarity that foregrounds epistemic grounding as a condition for legitimate disciplinary extension.

Keywords: disciplinary identity, interdisciplinarity, epistemic grounding, epistemic pluralism, titularity

1. Introduction

In recent decades, interdisciplinarity has become a defining feature of contemporary scientific practice, reshaping not only the organization of research but also the philosophical understanding of disciplines themselves. From early programmatic visions of interdisciplinary integration (Apostel et al., 1972) to later accounts of the new production of knowledge (Gibbons et al., 1994), the trajectory of modern science has increasingly emphasized problem-orientation, collaboration, and the crossing of disciplinary boundaries. Philosophical reflection has followed suit. Rather than treating disciplines as stable, self-contained units, recent work has foregrounded their dynamic interactions, their permeability, and their dependence on broader epistemic and institutional contexts (Mäki, 2016; Schmidt, 2008).

At the same time, however, this shift has generated a fundamental tension. Interdisciplinarity is frequently associated with epistemic pluralism---the coexistence of diverse methods, perspectives, and standards of inquiry---but it is also often expected to yield some form of integration or coherence. As Talbi and van Woerden (2025) emphasize, interdisciplinary practice is characterized by persistent epistemological conflicts that arise when distinct disciplinary traditions confront incompatible assumptions about evidence, explanation, and validity. These conflicts reflect deeper divergences in what counts as legitimate knowledge. Yet, what remains underexplored is whether such conflicts, when unresolved, merely complicate collaboration or actually transform the epistemic identity of the disciplines involved.

This tension between pluralism and integration has been widely noted in the philosophical literature. Traditional accounts of interdisciplinarity, influenced by thinkers such as Jantsch, have tended to emphasize conceptual or theoretical integration as the defining feature of successful interdisciplinary work. More recent analysis, however, has questioned whether such integration is always attainable or even desirable. Thorén and Persson (2013, 2023) distinguish between bilateral problem-feeding, in which solutions return to the source discipline, and unilateral problem-feeding, in which they do not. While they treat bilateral problem-feeding as a legitimate non-integrative form of interdisciplinarity, I argue that unilateral problem-feeding, when sustained over time, can function as a mechanism of what I call epistemic substitution, a process in which the epistemic goods of a source discipline are progressively displaced by those of a receiving discipline. This diagnosis goes beyond Thorén and Persson's account by specifying the conditions under which problem-feeding becomes epistemically degenerative.

Yet, this shift raises a deeper philosophical issue that remains insufficiently addressed. If interdisciplinary fields can operate without integration, and if they can draw on multiple epistemic systems without resolving their differences, then what becomes of disciplinary identity itself? Disciplinary identity can involve both internal coherence and social processes through which members identify with a discipline (Hyland, 2012; Osbeck & Nersessian, 2017). The present study focuses on internal coherence, which is the alignment of epistemic goods that enables problem-solving within a field. This focus is justified by the argument that when internal coherence

is undermined through epistemic substitution, the evaluative framework of the field loses its integrity. The question of whether a field is distinguishable from neighboring disciplines is secondary to the question of whether its own standards of evaluation remain coherent.¹

As Schmidt (2008) already observed, the term “interdisciplinarity” is frequently used in ways that are vague, functioning more as a rhetorical label than as a precisely defined concept. This raises the possibility that disciplinary designations, particularly those of the form “applied X”, may persist even when the underlying epistemic structures they presuppose have been fundamentally altered. The specific case of “applied” disciplines has received comparatively little philosophical attention. The label “applied X” appears to imply a particular kind of relationship between an applied domain and its parent discipline, one in which theoretical insights are extended into practical contexts. However, it remains unclear under what conditions this relationship holds. Existing discussions of interdisciplinarity have focused primarily on mechanisms of collaboration (National Academy of Sciences, 2005), patterns of knowledge exchange, or the measurement of interdisciplinarity (Wang & Schneider, 2020), rather than on the criteria that distinguish epistemic extension from epistemic transformation.

I address this gap by examining the conditions under which an applied field retains or loses its epistemic grounding in its parent discipline. Unlike existing approaches that substantially study disciplinary collaboration, the present framework offers a diagnostic criterion: whether an applied field preserves continuity in core epistemic goods. This criterion is both more precise than general calls for pluralism and more principled than institutional classifications. It argues that the designation “applied X” presupposes not merely a historical or institutional connection, but an ongoing alignment with the core problem space and epistemic aims of X. When such alignment is preserved, application can be understood as an extension of disciplinary knowledge. When it is not, the applied field may instead constitute a distinct epistemic domain, despite retaining its original name. In such cases, disciplinary identity becomes titular.

To develop this argument, I turn to applied linguistics as a particularly illuminating case. Applied

¹ In the following section, I show that what is problematic is the persistence of a label that no longer reflects the epistemic standards actually governing inquiry, as this undermines the comparability of knowledge claims and the transparency of evaluative practices.

linguistics has long defined itself in explicitly pluralistic and interdisciplinary terms, emphasizing its engagement with a wide range of social, educational, and psychological issues (Kaplan, 2010; *Applied Linguistics* journal, 1980-now). This orientation aligns with broader trends in problem-driven interdisciplinarity, in which research is organized around practical challenges rather than disciplinary boundaries (Papo & Potlimbrzović, 2023). However, as will be argued, this commitment to pluralism has also been accompanied by a shift in epistemic grounding. Rather than maintaining a stable relationship with linguistic theory, applied linguistics has increasingly drawn on frameworks from other disciplines, often without reintegrating these insights into a linguistically grounded framework.

From the perspective of the philosophy of interdisciplinarity, this development can be understood as a transition from integrative to asymmetrical forms of knowledge exchange. In terms of Thorén and Persson's (2013) framework, it resembles a case of unilateral problem-feeding, in which problems originating in one domain are addressed using the conceptual resources of another, without a corresponding return flow of solutions. Such a configuration challenges the assumption that applied fields necessarily remain anchored in their parent disciplines and raises the possibility that disciplinary labels may persist even as epistemic commitments shift.

The implications of this analysis extend beyond applied linguistics. They call into question the assumption that disciplinary identity can be sustained independently of epistemic continuity and suggest that the proliferation of interdisciplinary and applied fields may involve more profound transformations than is commonly recognized. In light of this, the present study addresses two central questions:

1. Under what epistemic conditions does an applied discipline remain grounded in its parent field, and under what conditions does it evolve into a distinct domain despite retaining its titular designation?
2. More broadly, how can the ideal of epistemic pluralism be reconciled with the need for disciplinary coherence, and when does it instead contribute to its erosion?

2. Epistemic grounding and the conditions of disciplinary identity

Philosophical accounts of interdisciplinarity have traditionally focused on the conditions under which knowledge from distinct disciplines can be coordinated, integrated, or productively combined. From early system-oriented analyses of interdisciplinarity (Apostel et al., 1972) to later developments in the theory of knowledge production (Gibbons et al., 1994), the dominant concern has been how disciplinary boundaries are crossed. Yet this focus on interaction has often come at the expense of a more fundamental question: what secures the identity of a discipline such that boundary-crossing remains intelligible as inter-disciplinary rather than simply post-disciplinary? Turner (2000) has gone further, arguing that disciplines are neither reducible to styles of reasoning nor to object domains. The epistemic grounding thesis offers a third alternative: what secures disciplinary identity is the alignment of epistemic goods, which need not coincide with either methodological style or subject matter.

Existing literature provides important but ultimately incomplete answers. Classic discussions of integration emphasize conceptual or theoretical coordination across fields (Bechtel, 1986; Darden & Maull, 1977), while subsequent critiques have stressed the fragmentation and disunity of science (Hacking, 1996; Grantham, 2004). Meanwhile, sociologically oriented accounts of knowledge production have highlighted the emergence of “mode two” research, characterized by contextualization, transdisciplinarity, and problem-orientation (Gibbons et al., 1994). However, these approaches tend to treat disciplinary identity as either stable or secondary, presupposing rather than theorizing the conditions under which a field remains meaningfully connected to its disciplinary origins.

I propose that disciplinary identity must instead be understood in terms of epistemic grounding. Whereas mode two describes institutional and problem-oriented shifts in knowledge production, the epistemic grounding thesis provides a criterion for assessing when such shifts preserve versus sever the connection of a field to its parent discipline. Drawing on insights from both philosophy of science and interdisciplinary studies, I argue that disciplines are not primarily defined by their object domains or methodological repertoires, but by their alignment with specific configurations of epistemic goods and problem spaces. While object domains may overlap and methods may be

shared across fields, what distinguishes one discipline from another is the set of epistemic priorities that organizes inquiry, namely whether the aim is, for instance, the explanation of underlying structures, the construction of predictive models, or the optimization of practical interventions.

This perspective finds indirect support in several strands of the literature. For instance, discussions of modeling practices across disciplines have emphasized that even when similar formal tools are employed, their epistemic roles may differ significantly depending on disciplinary context (Morgan & Grüne-Yanoff, 2012; Weisberg et al., 2010). Likewise, research on interdisciplinary collaboration has shown that successful integration requires not only methodological compatibility but also alignment at the level of underlying assumptions and evaluative standards (Hoffmann et al., 2013; Hirsch Hadorn, 2008). Here, the alignment is further grounded in shared commitments to the explanation of generative mechanisms, without which interdisciplinary work risks devolving into superficial juxtaposition (Bhaskar, 2008; Danermark, 2002).

Building on these insights, I formulate the epistemic grounding thesis: an applied discipline qualifies as an extension of its parent field only insofar as it preserves continuity in its core epistemic goods and problem space. The thesis resonates with Kuhnian account of disciplinary matrices as enabling problem-solving (Politi, 2026), but extends it by specifying epistemic goods as the central dimension along which continuity or rupture should be assessed. Where the continuity is maintained, application can be understood as epistemic extension, the deployment of existing theoretical resources in new contexts without altering their fundamental orientation. This corresponds, in classical terms, to forms of interdisciplinarity that retain a degree of conceptual integration or coordination (Bechtel, 1986). By contrast, overly prioritizing intervention without theoretical explanation triggers epistemic substitution, breaking the original epistemic extension of a field to its parent discipline. In such cases, the relationship to the parent discipline is no longer one of extension but of transformation.

My diagnosis challenges a widely held assumption in discussions of applied research, namely that the difference between “pure” and “applied” disciplines is primarily one of practical orientation. As the literature on transdisciplinarity has shown, problem-oriented research often entails a reconfiguration of both epistemic aims and evaluative criteria (Pohl, 2005; National Academy of

Sciences, 2005). However, what has not been sufficiently emphasized is that such reconfiguration may fundamentally alter the epistemic identity of the field. When the central questions of inquiry are no longer derived from the theoretical concerns of the parent discipline, but from external problem contexts, the resulting field may no longer share the same epistemic grounding, even if it retains the same name.

I propose three diagnostic indicators. First, an applied field counts as epistemic extension if its research problems are predominantly derived from theoretical puzzles within the parent discipline. For instance, a majority of problem statements in a representative corpus cite a core theoretical question from the field. Second, extension holds if the primary criterion for solution adequacy remains internal to the field (e.g. theoretical parsimony or explanatory depth), whereas substitution is indicated by a shift toward external criteria (e.g. intervention effectiveness, policy relevance). Third, substitution is indicated by a pattern of epistemic dependence, in which the knowledge production of a field becomes structurally reliant on frameworks from outside the parent discipline (Andersen & Wagenknecht, 2013). This dependence can be operationalized bibliometrically: a field exhibits substitution when its out-citations to the parent discipline decline below incoming citations from it, combined with rising citation centrality of journals from other fields (Wang & Schneider, 2020). These criteria, while not exhaustive, offer a preliminary scaffold for distinguishing extension from substitution in future empirical studies.

It is useful to distinguish among three analytically separable dimensions of disciplinary organization: (i) object domain, (ii) epistemic goods, and (iii) methodological practices. While all three contribute to the characterization of a field, the present argument assigns explanatory primacy to the second. Object domains are often porous, as evidenced by the extensive overlap of subject matter across disciplines (Coase, 1978). Methodological practices are likewise transferable, as demonstrated by the widespread use of similar modeling techniques in both natural and social sciences (Morgan & Grüne-Yanoff, 2012). By contrast, epistemic goods---what counts as a satisfactory explanation, a valid result, or a meaningful contribution---are more resistant to transfer and play a decisive role in structuring disciplinary inquiry.

The emphasis on epistemic goods also allows us to reinterpret debates on the unity and disunity of

science. Rather than asking whether scientific knowledge can be reduced to a single framework (Nagel, 1961) or whether it is irreducibly pluralistic (Hacking, 1996), the present approach suggests that unity and disunity are functions of shared or divergent epistemic grounding. Disciplines may coexist within a broader scientific enterprise while maintaining distinct identities, provided that their epistemic goods remain internally coherent. However, when a field shifts its epistemic commitments without corresponding changes in its titular designation, a mismatch arises between name and identity.

The mismatch can be further illuminated by considering the role of institutional structures in sustaining disciplinary categories. As studies of interdisciplinary research have shown, institutional arrangements (e.g. funding regimes, evaluation criteria, and organizational affiliations) often lag behind epistemic developments (Kessel et al., 2003; Klein, 2008). Consequently, a field may continue to be classified under a particular disciplinary label even after its epistemic orientation has diverged significantly from that of its supposed parent. This phenomenon, which will be developed in later sections as disciplinary institutional drift, highlights the importance of distinguishing between nominal and epistemic criteria of disciplinary identity.

The epistemic grounding thesis thus provides a framework for analyzing not only the conditions under which applied disciplines remain connected to their parent fields, but also the circumstances under which such connections become merely nominal. It shifts the focus from surface features (e.g. terminology, institutional affiliation, or declared object of study) to the deeper structure of epistemic commitments that sustain disciplinary practice. In doing so, it offers a criterion for evaluating the legitimacy of “applied” designations across fields.

In the sections that follow, I bring this framework into dialogue with contemporary debates on interdisciplinarity and epistemic pluralism, before applying it to a concrete case. The aim is to demonstrate that the proliferation of applied and interdisciplinary fields is not merely a matter of expanding knowledge, but also involves the potential reconfiguration and, in some cases, the erosion of disciplinary identity itself.

3. From integration to problem-feeding: the limits of epistemic pluralism

While early work framed interdisciplinarity in terms of theoretical coordination across domains (Darden & Maull, 1977), more recent approaches have emphasized the epistemic and practical necessity of pluralism in addressing complex, real-world problems (Coliva & Pedersen, 2017; Funtowicz & Ravetz, 1993). Yet, as has been increasingly recognized, the coexistence of multiple perspectives does not by itself guarantee epistemic productivity. The crucial issue is under what conditions it contributes to coherent knowledge production rather than to epistemic fragmentation.

The concept of problem-feeding, first introduced by Thorén and Persson (2013) and expanded in their 2023 analysis, frames interdisciplinary exchanges as either bilateral (with reciprocal problem and solution circulation) or unilateral one-way transfers. They outline three non-negotiable prerequisites for sustainable bilateral exchange: conceptual-ontological alignment, epistemological-methodological trust, and axiological harmonisation. Breakdown along any of these three dimensions terminates reciprocal solution-feeding and locks disciplines into unilateral problem transfer, a structural dependency they label a Type III error, driven primarily by axiological misalignment. Under such breakdown, solutions are reframed to fit the epistemic commitments of a receiving field and become untranslatable against the core explanatory benchmarks of a source discipline.

While full misalignment accelerates this shift, partial alignment of the three prerequisites only slows rather than prevents long-term epistemic substitution, where the standards for valid explanation of a source field are gradually supplanted by the evaluative norms of a recipient field. Thorén and Persson's framework offers a typology of cross-field exchange; my account advances a normative causal mechanism, reinterpreting this Type III distortion as cumulative disciplinary erosion brought on by degenerative pluralism. This diagnosis moves past the standard integration–pluralism binary to centre the direction of epistemic authority: classic integration models presuppose two-way mutual adjustment between fields (Bechtel, 1986; Star & Griesemer, 1989), whereas unilateral problem-feeding enables problem cross-border transfer without reciprocal circulation of epistemic authority.

The asymmetry has significant consequences. When a discipline imports solutions from another domain without a corresponding return flow of epistemic authority, it may retain the capacity to assess imported solutions against its own epistemic standards. The risk arises when external standards become internalized without being subjected to critical scrutiny, a process that may occur gradually as imported frameworks prove pragmatically effective and their assumptions become taken for granted. In such cases, the evaluative criteria of a source discipline are displaced through cumulative practical adoption. What begins as a pragmatic strategy for addressing intractable problems thus evolves into a more profound transformation of epistemic identity. This dynamic can be further clarified by drawing on the notion of epistemic cultures (Cetina, 1999). Different disciplines instantiate distinct configurations of epistemic goods, including divergent conceptions of what counts as an adequate explanation or a meaningful result. When unilateral problem-feeding occurs among disciplines with incompatible epistemic cultures, a receiving discipline necessarily reinterprets the problem in terms of its own epistemic framework. The solution produced is a transformation of the original problem, one that reflects the epistemic priorities of a receiving discipline rather than those of an originating one. I typically note that exporting problems to another discipline may reflect a legitimate acknowledgment of disciplinary limits. The concern arises only when imported solutions are adopted without critical assessment against the standards of a source discipline.

At this point, the limitations of epistemic pluralism become apparent. Pluralism is often defended on the grounds that multiple perspectives can jointly contribute to a more comprehensive understanding of complex phenomena. However, this defense presupposes that the different perspectives are, at least in principle, commensurable or capable of coordination. When the participating disciplines are oriented toward fundamentally different epistemic goods, pluralism does not yield integration but instead facilitates epistemic degeneration. In such cases, the coexistence of perspectives masks an underlying shift in epistemic authority.

My observation motivates a distinction between two forms of pluralism. Integrative pluralism corresponds to cases in which multiple perspectives contribute to a shared epistemic project, even if they retain distinct methods or assumptions. Degenerative pluralism, by contrast, arises when the introduction of additional perspectives leads to the marginalization or displacement of the original

epistemic framework.² This is still pluralism in the minimal sense that multiple perspectives coexist; what distinguishes the two only has to do with its effect. Nor should degeneration be conflated with multidisciplinary as such. As Mennes (2020) argues, multidisciplinary juxtaposition can be epistemically valuable and does not imply inferiority. Degenerative pluralism is a specific condition in which pluralism, unconstrained by shared epistemic grounding, facilitates substitution, which is a diagnostic claim about effects.

The concept of degenerative pluralism allows us to reinterpret problem-feeding as a specific mechanism through which epistemic degeneration occurs. In problem-feeding, the asymmetrical transfer of problems creates a situation in which one discipline's epistemic goods are systematically subordinated to those of another. This process is not necessarily intentional; it may emerge from practical considerations, such as the relative availability of methods or the perceived effectiveness of certain approaches. Nevertheless, its cumulative effect is to erode the epistemic distinctiveness of the originating discipline.

Importantly, this erosion is not immediately visible at the level of institutional or nominal classification. A field may continue to be identified with a particular discipline while operating according to a different set of epistemic goods. The result is a form of latent disciplinary transformation, in which changes in epistemic grounding are obscured by continuity in nomenclature. Hence, a critical question emerges: under what conditions does pluralism support rather than undermine disciplinary coherence? I propose that the answer depends on whether pluralism is constrained by a shared epistemic grounding. Where such grounding is present, pluralism can enhance the robustness of inquiry by incorporating multiple perspectives into a coherent framework. Where it is absent, pluralism becomes a vehicle for epistemic degeneration, facilitating the gradual replacement of one set of epistemic goods by another.

The concern leads to a refinement of the normative role of pluralism in interdisciplinary research. Pesch and van Uffelen (2024) argue that no normative paradigm should dominate; different paradigms serve as complementary scales of contextualisation. That claim concerns the level of

² Clarke and Walsh's (2009) proposal about imperialism involves one discipline actively expanding into another's domain, often imposing its methodology on a weaker discipline. The mechanism identified here is internal to the evolving practices of a field and does not presuppose any expansionist intent or interdisciplinary power asymmetry.

moral judgment. The present analysis operates at a different level: epistemic grounding and disciplinary identity. Even if normative plurality requires coexistence without hierarchy, epistemic plurality does not. Interdisciplinary collaboration remains intelligible only if participating fields share a minimal structure of epistemic goods that defines what counts as knowledge within a domain. Without such grounding, pluralism degenerates from complementarity into fragmentation.³ The limits of epistemic pluralism are more adequately captured regarding epistemic coherence, insofar as some minimal alignment of epistemic goods appears necessary for maintaining disciplinary intelligibility. Hence, much of what is currently described as successful interdisciplinarity may involve forms of epistemic degeneration that remain unacknowledged. By focusing on the presence of collaboration or the diversity of perspectives, existing evaluations may overlook the deeper question of how epistemic authority is distributed and transformed. As a result, the ideal of pluralism may inadvertently legitimize processes that undermine the very conditions for coherent disciplinary inquiry.

My argument does not advocate rigid disciplinary insularity or demand full theoretical unification across fields. I argue that intellectual humility requires acknowledging when the core inquiry of an “applied” domain no longer answers the parent discipline’s theoretical questions, rather than masking epistemic reorientation under inherited titular labels. Voluntary, mutually aligned bilateral problem-feeding (Thorén & Persson, 2023) remains the gold standard for non-imperialist interdisciplinary collaboration.

In this sense, the limits of epistemic pluralism arise from the tension between diversity and grounding. Recognizing such limits necessitates specifying the conditions under which pluralism remains epistemically coherent rather than degenerative. The distinction between integrative and degenerative pluralism, together with the analysis of problem-feeding as a mechanism of epistemic degeneration, offers a principled way to diagnose when interdisciplinary engagement preserves an epistemic grounding of a discipline and when it facilitates its transformation. Crucially, this framework also makes it possible to move beyond abstract discussions of interdisciplinarity and to

³ The term “degeneration” is not used here in Lakatos’s sense of a research programme that consistently fails to anticipate novel facts (Branahl, 2025). I operationally define degeneration as the erosion of the internal coherence of a discipline through the displacement of its core epistemic goods by external standards. A programme may be epistemically degenerative without being Lakatosianly degenerative, and vice versa.

examine how such dynamics unfold within concrete fields. In particular, it raises the question of whether domains that present themselves as “applied” extensions of a parent discipline in fact operate through epistemic extension or through epistemic substitution. The following section addresses this question by turning to a specific case, showing how the mechanisms identified here can lead to a divergence between titular designation and epistemic identity.

4. Titularity without identity: the case of applied linguistics

I refer to applied linguistics to demonstrate the central claim developed in the previous section, namely, that disciplinary identity depends on the continuity of epistemic goods and core problem space. The case of applied linguistics illustrates how a field may shift from epistemic extension to epistemic substitution. This shift reflects a reconfiguration of epistemic goods and problem space. Where earlier configurations were at least partially oriented toward applying linguistic theory to practical domains (e.g. Lamendella, 1969), many current configurations are organized around problem domains whose epistemic orientation is no longer anchored in linguistics as a theoretical enterprise (Weideman, 2016). The result is a transformation in the conditions that would justify the label “applied linguistics” in the first place. What makes it a concern is that the persistence of the inherited label obscures the epistemic basis of research and the transparency of evaluative standards within the field.

Weideman (2016) offers a different account of the distinctiveness of applied linguistics, proposing a distinction between the “lingual” modality (concerned with language as an object of inquiry) and the “technical” modality (oriented toward the design of interventions in problem domains). While this framework provides a principled basis for differentiating the two domains, it remains primarily conceptual. What it leaves less clear is how shifts in problem space and epistemic goods unfold over time, and how such shifts may lead to a gradual decoupling from the parent discipline. It is precisely this dynamic process that the present account seeks to capture in terms of epistemic substitution.

On the epistemic grounding thesis, disciplinary identity is defined by the continuity of epistemic

goods and core problem space. In linguistics, these goods are centrally oriented toward explaining language as a structured system, whether in formal or cognitive-functional approaches. Despite theoretical disagreements, these approaches share a commitment to explaining linguistic competence, structure, or usage as primary objects of inquiry. By contrast, a significant body of work within applied linguistics is oriented toward epistemic goods such as pedagogical effectiveness, social equity, identity construction, or policy intervention (Block, 2003; Pennycook, 2022). This reorientation marks a shift toward a different set of epistemic priorities.

Such a shift can't be adequately captured by the standard narrative of increasing interdisciplinarity. As emphasized in the philosophy of interdisciplinarity, interdisciplinarity encompasses a range of configurations, including integration, coordination, and juxtaposition (Klein, 1990; Barry et al., 2008). What is distinctive in the present case is an asymmetrical restructuring of epistemic authority: linguistics no longer functions as the primary source of theoretical grounding; instead, frameworks from education, sociology, and critical theory increasingly define both the problems and the criteria for their resolution.

This pattern instantiates the mechanism of unilateral problem-feeding analyzed in section 3. Applied linguistics, in many contemporary forms, does not primarily apply linguistic theory to external problems. It imports problem formulations from external domains and addresses them using non-linguistic epistemic frameworks. Research on language education, for instance, often adopts constructs from educational psychology (e.g. Cheng et al., 2025), while studies of discourse and identity draw on sociological and post-structuralist theories (e.g. Block, 2007; Norton, 2014). In such cases, findings are connected to broader analytical frameworks not grounded in linguistic theory. The direction of exchange is asymmetrical because applied linguistics imports solutions from other disciplines, but these imports are not re-integrated into a linguistically grounded framework. From this perspective, the pattern constitutes a case of epistemic substitution: linguistic epistemic goods cease to function as the organizing principle of inquiry, and criteria of explanatory success are defined in relation to external problem domains. The relationship between applied linguistics and linguistics thus becomes nominal rather than epistemic.

My diagnosis challenges a widely held self-conception within applied linguistics, according to

which the scholarly strength lies precisely in its openness to multiple perspectives and its responsiveness to real-world concerns (Kaplan, 2010; *Applied Linguistics* journal, 1980-now). While such openness is often framed as a virtue, it also raises a critical question: openness to what, and under what constraints? Without a stable epistemic grounding, openness risks becoming indistinguishable from indeterminacy. The proliferation of perspectives may then reflect the absence of a unifying framework.

The literature on interdisciplinarity provides resources for making this point more precise. Studies of interdisciplinary collaboration have shown that successful integration requires diversity and mechanisms for coordinating and evaluating contributions (Huutoniemi et al., 2010; Rafols & Meyer, 2010). In the absence of such mechanisms, interdisciplinarity may result in what has been described as “fragmented adhocracy”, characterized by loosely connected research practices without a shared epistemic core. Applied linguistics, in its current configuration, exhibits many of these features: a wide range of topics, methods, and theoretical orientations (Phakiti et al., 2018), but limited agreement on what constitutes a central cumulative body of knowledge in relation to linguistics.

One might object that this characterization overlooks strands of applied linguistics that remain closely connected to linguistic theory, such as second language acquisition research informed by generative linguistics (e.g. Slabakova et al., 2020) or usage-based models (e.g. Cadierno & Eskildsen, 2015). This objection is accepted but does not undermine the present claim. Indeed, not every contribution to applied linguistics has severed its epistemic grounding, but the disciplinary center of gravity, measured by publication volume, citation impact, and self-definition in leading journals, has shifted toward non-linguistic epistemic goods (Meihami & Esfandiari, 2024). What matters for the charge of titularity without identity is that the dominant, field-defining trajectory no longer requires linguistic grounding, such that a researcher can be a recognized contributor to general humanities. The persistence of linguistically grounded subfields only confirms that the field is epistemically stratified, not that the stratification is harmless to disciplinary coherence.

A more substantial objection is that the reorientation of applied linguistics toward social and educational concerns reflects a legitimate expansion of its scope, rather than a loss of identity. From

this perspective, the field has simply evolved to address more complex and socially relevant problems, and its interdisciplinarity is a necessary response to those challenges (Schmitz, 2010). While this argument has intuitive appeal, it presupposes that disciplinary identity can be preserved independently of epistemic grounding. The framework developed in this study rejects this presupposition. Expansion of scope is compatible with continuity of identity only if the underlying epistemic goods remain aligned with those of the parent discipline. When they do not, the result is not expansion but transformation.

The distinction can be clarified by returning to the concept of epistemic goods. In linguistics, these goods are oriented toward the explanation of linguistic phenomena, whether in terms of formal structure, cognitive representation, or functional usage. In many areas of applied linguistics, however, the primary goods are evaluative or interventionist, such as improving educational outcomes (Huang & Chalmers, 2023), promoting social justice (e.g. Keleş, 2026), or informing policy (e.g. McEntee-Atalianis & Hult, 2025). These aims are not reducible to linguistic explanation, nor are they necessarily constrained by it. As a result, the criteria for success in these domains diverge from those of linguistics, further weakening the epistemic connection between the two fields. The consequence of misclassification has substantive implications for how research is conducted, evaluated, and legitimized. When the label “applied linguistics” is used to encompass research that is not grounded in linguistic epistemic goods, the comparability of knowledge claims within the discipline is undermined, and with it the very possibility of maintaining a coherent disciplinary evaluative framework.

At this point, the notion of titularity without identity can be specified more precisely. A field exhibits titularity without identity when its name suggests a relation to a parent discipline that is not borne out by its epistemic structure. In the case of applied linguistics, the titular reference to linguistics implies a grounding in the study of natural languages as such. The confusion arises for policy makers, funding bodies, researchers from other fields, students, and the public, who look at disciplinary labels to understand what a field does and what standards it holds. When the label no longer reliably signals the epistemic commitments of the field, it creates practical problems for evaluation and collaboration across institutional boundaries.

My analysis does not entail that applied linguistics is illegitimate as a field of inquiry. On the contrary, the problems it addresses, like language education, multilingualism, and critical discourse, are of undeniable importance. The issue is central to the coherence of the disciplinary framework within which they are pursued. If the epistemic orientation is primarily aligned with education, sociology, or cultural studies, then it may be more appropriate to classify it accordingly. Retaining the label “applied linguistics” under such conditions risks conflating distinct epistemic projects and obscuring their respective standards of validity. In this sense, applied linguistics provides a paradigmatic example of how epistemic substitution can lead to a divergence between titular designation and disciplinary identity. It illustrates how the mechanisms identified in previous sections, especially problem-feeding and degenerative pluralism, can operate at the level of an entire field, producing a condition in which epistemic grounding is progressively displaced while nominal continuity is preserved. The following analysis examines how institutional structures contribute to the stabilization and reproduction of such conditions, thereby transforming what might otherwise be a transient phase into a durable feature of the academic landscape.

5. Institutional drift and the reproduction of disciplinary misclassification

I have shown that unregulated epistemic pluralism and unilateral problem-feeding enable applied fields to shift from epistemic extension to epistemic substitution. Yet this framework remains incomplete without an account of why dislocated fields retain inherited “applied X” labels rather than undergoing formal disciplinary reclassification. This section introduces the concept of disciplinary institutional drift to explain the structural forces stabilising mismatches between nominal disciplinary identity and underlying epistemic commitments, drawing path-dependence analogies from institutional policy scholarship (Wiley & Reed, 2024).

Disciplinary institutional drift describes a decoupling process. The evaluative, funding and organisational infrastructures of a field persist with their traditional naming conventions, even as core epistemic goods diverge from the parent discipline. Sustained by academic incentive structures, authority hierarchies and accumulated symbolic capital (Glasford & Brown, 2025), this mismatch between titularity and epistemic identity becomes a durable, structurally embedded state rather than

a temporary transitional quirk.

Science studies scholarship frames disciplines as dual constructs: they function both as coherent epistemic systems and institutionalised knowledge apparatuses sustained by departments, journals, professional bodies and funding pipelines (Whitley, 2024). These institutional arrangements exhibit strong path dependence, reproducing long-standing disciplinary taxonomies independently of evolving research practices (Weideman, 2016). Epistemic evolution therefore rarely triggers parallel institutional restructuring, creating persistent gaps between official field categorisation and actual evaluative standards.

Such institutional decoupling does not unfold uniformly across all applied domains. Formalised fields such as applied mathematics and applied physics enforce strict theoretical continuity with their parent disciplines, requiring all applied outputs to be translatable into the parent's formal theoretical vocabulary (Pérez-Escobar & Sarikaya, 2022). This creates a constant feedback loop securing the parent field's explanatory authority and blocking wholesale epistemic substitution. By contrast, social and humanistic applied fields studying context-dependent phenomena lack unified formal systems to anchor inquiry; applied success may be judged by external practical benchmarks without theoretical reintegration, making epistemic substitution far more institutionally feasible.

Applied linguistics embodies this structural asymmetry. While its institutional architecture (e.g. university programmes, flagship journals, dedicated funding streams) retains the label “linguistics”, its dominant research priorities have shifted toward external social and educational problem domains, generating a permanent split between titular continuity and epistemic discontinuity. Three mutually reinforcing institutional mechanisms lock this misclassification in place. First, research assessment frameworks define excellence along field-specific rather than parent-discipline epistemic lines (Lamont, 2009). Within applied linguistics, evaluative benchmarks prioritise educational impact, social equity and methodological pluralism over alignment with linguistic explanatory frameworks (Li et al., 2025), incentivising scholars to orient inquiry toward external epistemic goods and accelerating substitution. Second, contemporary funding regimes prioritise problem-centred, socially impactful interdisciplinary work (Nowotny et al., 2021). Research addressing educational or societal intervention receives disproportionate resource support relative to

work centred on linguistic theoretical explanation, further skewing the field's epistemic centre of gravity. Third, journal editorial policies institutionalise broad, socially oriented scope remits (*Applied Linguistics* journal, 1980-now; *Language & Education* journal, 1987-now; *System* journal, 1973-now), elevating non-linguistic problem frames in publication and citation cycles and gradually redefining the field's core epistemic territory.

Three interconnected institutional processes, namely reoriented evaluation criteria, impact-centred funding priorities, and socially focused journal gatekeeping, operate as a self-reinforcing feedback loop that normalizes epistemic substitution under unchanged disciplinary branding. This structural reproduction rarely faces critical pushback, as mainstream interdisciplinary discourse valorises unconstrained pluralism as an inherent virtue (Dewaele, 2019), supplying normative narratives that obscure the erosion of parent-discipline epistemic grounding. A striking paradox emerges: applied linguistics has expanded its institutional footprint via new degrees, journals and professional organisations even as its reliance on linguistic core epistemic goods weakens, demonstrating that institutional growth bears no necessary relation to epistemic coherence.

My institutional analysis carries wider philosophical implications for theories of disciplinary identity. Standard accounts often treat disciplinary classifications as fundamentally epistemic, but the drift framework reveals a persistent dual separation between epistemic core commitments and institutional labelling. The three institutional mechanisms outlined above operationalise this divide, showing how nominal disciplinary categories persist despite radical shifts in what counts as valid explanation within a field.

Epistemic substitution triggered by institutional drift generates both descriptive real-world costs and normative philosophical defects, a dual misclassification harm insufficiently foregrounded in prior interdisciplinary work. Descriptively, mislabelling confuses evaluators, graduate training designers and funding bodies, who can't reliably map the titular name of a field to its operative standards of evidence and explanation. Normatively, it invalidates the foundational presupposition of "applied X" as legitimate epistemic extension, which hinges on sustained alignment with the parent field's core problem space and explanatory aims. Thorén & Persson's (2023) three-dimensional preconditions for bilateral problem-feeding clarify why this dual harm arises. Permanent substitution severs the

conceptual and axiological alignment required for reciprocal cross-disciplinary dialogue, trapping the field in one-sided epistemic subordination that undermines coherent knowledge exchange, graduate curriculum design, and equitable resource allocation across academia.

My observation questions whether institutional drift should be resisted or accepted as a natural stage of knowledge evolution. The answer hinges on whether disciplinary epistemic coherence counts as an essential condition for rigorous, comparable problem-solving. If disciplines exist to sustain structured frameworks for targeted theoretical or practical inquiry, the loss of shared core epistemic goods constitutes a substantive intellectual cost, even when offset by greater social relevance or institutional expansion. A purely instrumental reading of scholarship might dismiss this coherence loss as negligible, yet misclassification carries tangible practical risks beyond abstract conceptual confusion. When work framed as “applied linguistics” mixes research governed by linguistic explanatory standards with inquiry oriented toward educational or sociological aims, uniform assessment of scholarly contributions becomes impossible, distorting training pathways, funding distribution, and public understanding of distinct research domains. Crucially, disciplinary transformation is not inherently degenerative: shifts qualify as legitimate epistemic extension so long as they retain alignment with the parent’s core epistemic goods and satisfy Thorén & Persson’s (2023) prerequisites for bilateral problem-feeding. Only sustained unilateral problem-feeding and full substitution produce the degenerative drift outlined in this chapter, avoiding the false binary that all interdisciplinary evolution erodes disciplinary identity.

In sum, titularity without identity can’t be fully analyzed without accounting for institutional drift as a stabilizing structural force. The three interconnected institutional mechanisms detailed above turn temporary epistemic divergence into a permanent feature of academic organization. By integrating institutional sociology with the epistemic grounding thesis, this analysis extends philosophy of interdisciplinarity into science policy and research governance, arguing that rigorous disciplinary evaluation and classification must account for both epistemic core commitments and the institutional structures that distort nominal field labels over time.

6. Conclusion

I have argued that disciplinary identity can't be secured by titular continuity alone, but depends on what has been termed an epistemic grounding condition: the alignment of the core problem space and epistemic goods with those of its parent discipline. By distinguishing between epistemic extension and epistemic substitution, and by reconceptualizing unilateral problem-feeding as a mechanism of epistemic degeneration, I show how applied fields may undergo substantive transformation while retaining their inherited names. The case of applied linguistics demonstrates that such transformations are stabilized through processes of disciplinary institutional drift. On broader implications, the contemporary celebration of interdisciplinarity and pluralism, when detached from conditions of epistemic grounding, risks legitimizing forms of disciplinary misclassification. If disciplinary identity is to retain analytical and normative significance, it must be evaluated not by institutional labels or rhetorical commitments to diversity, but by the underlying epistemic structures that define what counts as knowledge within a field.

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